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New Vest, Same Vigilance

A Fourteen-Week Survey of Warehouse Floor Staff Against Their Hi-Vis Vest Tier and Time on the Job

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Background

Hi-vis vest tiers let proximity-sensing machinery tell trainees from time-served staff at a glance. Adoption is near-universal across monitored sites. Whether the tier tracks anything about how safe a worker actually feels on shift has gone untested.

Aims

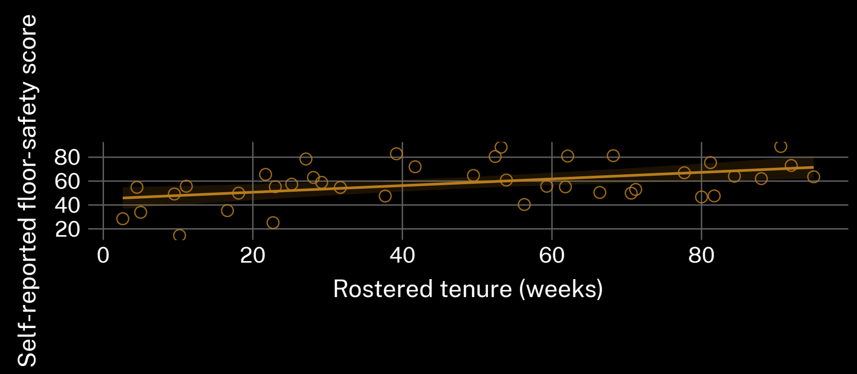
- Test whether vest tier predicts self-reported floor safety
- Compare tier against rostered tenure as a safety predictor
- Establish whether either outperforms a raw near-miss headcount

Methods

- n = 236 floor staff · 19 warehouses · anonymous exit-shift survey · 14 weeks
- Ordinal regression: self-reported safety   vest tier + tenure + near-misses
- Tier assignments held constant; no mid-trial re-tiering authorised at any site

Results

Vest tier showed no reliable association with self-reported safety once tenure was controlled for. Tenure alone predicted safety ratings about as well as tier and tenure combined.



Safety score rose with tenure (r = 0.46, n = 236, 19 warehouses, Apr–Jul 2026); vest tier alone showed none (r = 0.09).

Discussion & conclusions

A tier built for machinery reads as the floor's safety credential — unsupported by what workers feel. Tenure did the tier's job better than the tier did. Next: does dropping the visible ranking change reported safety, or only who gets asked.

References

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Anonymous exit-shift survey; no individual roster or near-miss record retained beyond the trial window. We thank the floor staff of the nineteen monitored warehouses.

"Same floor. Different vest. Same nerves."

Self-reported floor safety tracked tenure (r = 0.46), not vest tier (r = 0.09), across 19 warehouses.